

there are more women in manufacturing in urban India (*see graphic 'Women on the Shop Floor'*) than men. A visit to any of the large factories in the industrial parts of, say, Chennai, Vadodara, or Bengaluru makes this pretty obvious.

Shilpa Kabra Maheshwari, Executive Vice President and Country Head (People & Organisation) at Siemens India, which is focused on industry, infrastructure, digital transformation, transport and electrical power, believes that the rise in women's representation across the core sectors has largely been on account of the influence of technology and the work done in the STEM (science, technology, engineering, and mathematics) segment. Initiatives like the Vigyan Jyoti scheme by the government's Department of Science & Technology to address

the issue of under-representation of women in STEM has helped.

"Plus, over the last few years, a lot of companies have consciously worked towards hiring women in core sectors. This has started from the university level and metrics are in place to measure hiring and retention of women," she says.

Policies are now in place to provide flexible work programmes or to set up requisite infrastructure to enable a safe work environment—which includes maternity benefits and childcare. Speaking specifically for Siemens, Maheshwari says women head departments in areas such as treasury, electrification and automation solutions, digitisation and software business, factory and smart infrastructure, to name a few.

One interesting facet is how the change is taking place across lev-

els and functions. Take the case of L&T, where the gender diversity rate—according to Koneru Bhavani, Executive Vice President & Head (Urban Transit Systems Business Group)—stands at 8.1% for FY24, up from 5.57% a decade ago. "Besides, 30% of our GETs/PGETs (graduate and post graduate engineer trainee) for the last fiscal were women," she adds.

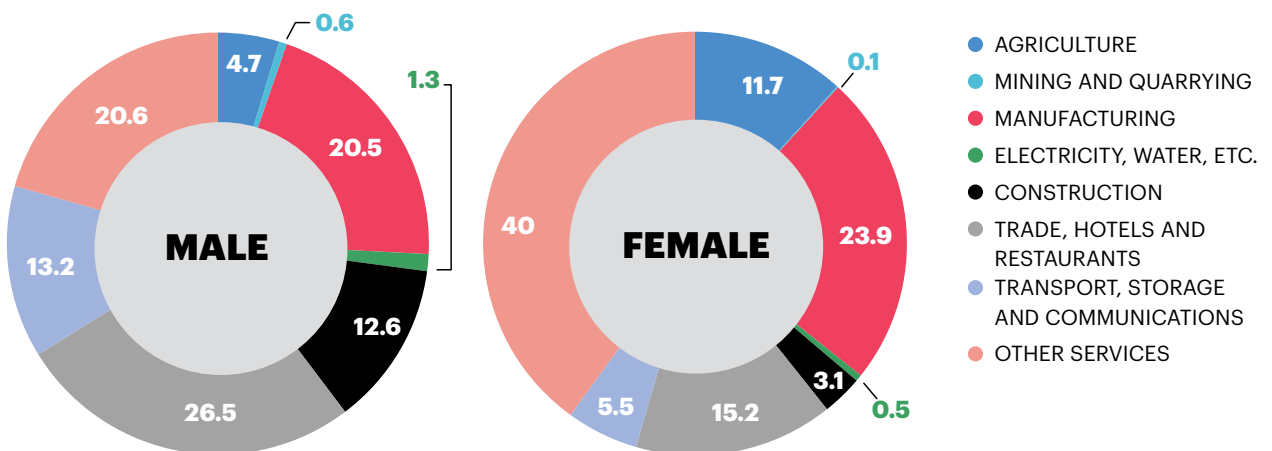
Bhavani herself joined the company in the early 1990s right out of engineering college and has been involved in big-ticket projects. "For women, the urge to be financially independent and the desire to be successful are the biggest motivators to give their best," she says.

Her achievements include leading projects such as the Jammu-Udhampur rail link, Mumbai monorail, Hyderabad metro and the high-

RE TEAM

THE URBAN BREAK-UP

- More manufacturing shifting to the larger centres and their outskirts has helped in employing a higher proportion of women



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